Chapter 24 | Written solutions

Speech and Audio

These eleven solutions move from samples and windows to transcript errors and live captions. Each answer explains the reasoning before checking it with small, deterministic examples. The figures show overlapping frames, tone frequencies and a changing caption.

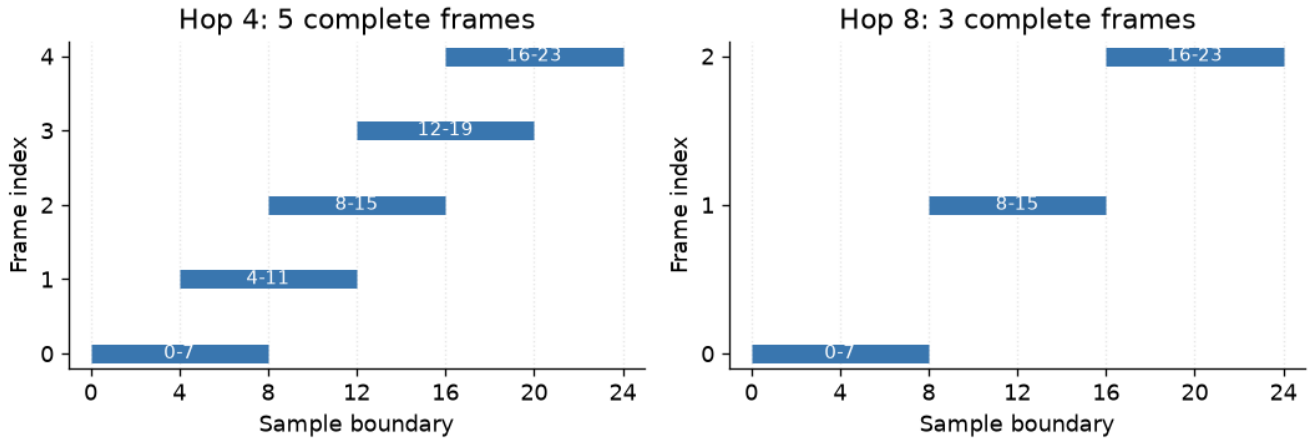
The examples use synthetic waveforms and supplied transcript histories. They illustrate calculations and evaluation protocols; they do not measure a trained speech recognizer.

1. Count complete frames

Number the 24 samples from 0 to 23. An eight-sample frame starting at s ends at $s + 7$, so the last possible start is 16. Advance by the hop until a complete frame would no longer fit.

Hop	Starts	Inclusive sample ranges	Shared samples per adjacent pair
4	0, 4, 8, 12, 16	0–7; 4–11; 8–15; 12–19; 16–23	4
8	0, 8, 16	0–7; 8–15; 16–23	0

The number of complete unpadded frames is $\max(0, 1 + \lfloor (L - N)/H \rfloor)$. For these settings it is five or three. In the plot, each horizontal segment covers eight sample intervals. Dashed lines are boundaries between sample intervals, so the endpoint of the last segment is 24 even though the last sample index is 23.



2. Read the axes

A bin checks an integer number of cycles in one frame. At $f_s = 8{,}000$ Hz and $N = 16$, the frame spans 2 ms. One cycle per frame is therefore 500 cycles per second. Bins 0, 1 and 8 represent 0, 500 and 4,000 Hz. The hop of eight samples separates starts by 1 ms.

Configuration	Window duration	Bin spacing f_s/N	Start spacing H/f_s
$N = 16, H = 8$	2 ms	500 Hz	1 ms
Change only N to 32	4 ms	250 Hz	1 ms
Restore $N = 16$; change only H to 4	2 ms	500 Hz	0.5 ms

Longer windows put bins closer together while combining a longer interval. Smaller hops add more overlapping measurements; each window still spans the same interval. Bin spacing and the ability to distinguish nearby tones are related but not identical. Simply relabeling the sample rate is not resampling the waveform.

3. Choose a decoding task

The spoken language is Spanish in both requests. In the original multilingual Whisper interface, the task specifies whether to transcribe that speech or translate it into English.

Request	Spoken language	Task	Example output
Spanish transcript	Spanish (`es`)	`transcribe`	Buenos días
English translation	Spanish (`es`)	`translate`	Good morning

Both requests supply the same recording and preprocessing, so the audio encoder receives the same log-Mel features. The decoder task token changes the requested output. Selecting English as the spoken language would misdescribe this recording. This original translation task does not mean translation into an arbitrary target language.

The following table is a supplied teaching fixture, not a model call. Compare a transcript with a transcript in the spoken language; use an appropriate translation reference when evaluating the translation task.

4. Align the words

Keep the agreeing words in order, substitute *red* for *blue*, and insert *now* at the end.

Reference	Hypothesis	Operation
turn	turn	Match
at	at	Match
the	the	Match
blue	red	Substitute
door	door	Match
gap	now	Insert

The sentences differ in length by one. A single-edit solution would therefore have to be an insertion, but that would preserve *blue*, which is absent from the hypothesis. At least two edits are needed, and the displayed alignment achieves two. Thus $(S, D, I) = (1, 0, 1)$ and WER is $2/5 = 40\%$.

Reversing the sentences reverses the insertion into a deletion. Each unit-cost edit can be undone with one edit, so the minimum distance stays two. The six-word reference now gives $2/6 = 1/3 \approx 33.3\%$. WER is asymmetric because it uses reference length, not because the unit-cost edit distance is asymmetric.

5. Check the spectrogram shape

The 16 zero samples have indices 0 through 15. An eight-sample frame starting at index s needs the samples through $s + 7$. Stepping by four gives three complete frames, covering indices 0–7, 4–11, and 8–15. A fourth frame starting at 12 would need samples through index 19, so the function drops it.

Each row of the power array corresponds to a frame start. Divide its start index by $f_s = 8{,}000$ samples per second to get $[0, 0.0005, 0.001]$ seconds, or $[0, 0.5, 1]$ milliseconds. Each column corresponds to a frequency bin. With $N = 8$ samples per frame, the spacing is $f_s/N = 1{,}000$ Hz. The real FFT keeps bins 0 through 4, from 0 Hz (the constant component) to 4,000 Hz (half the sample rate). Three starts and five frequencies give a power array of shape $(3, 5)$.

The Hann window multiplies each sample by a weight. All the samples remain zero, so every Fourier coefficient is zero. The function returns raw squared Fourier magnitudes, and all $3 \times 5 = 15$ entries are exactly zero.

6. Find a tone

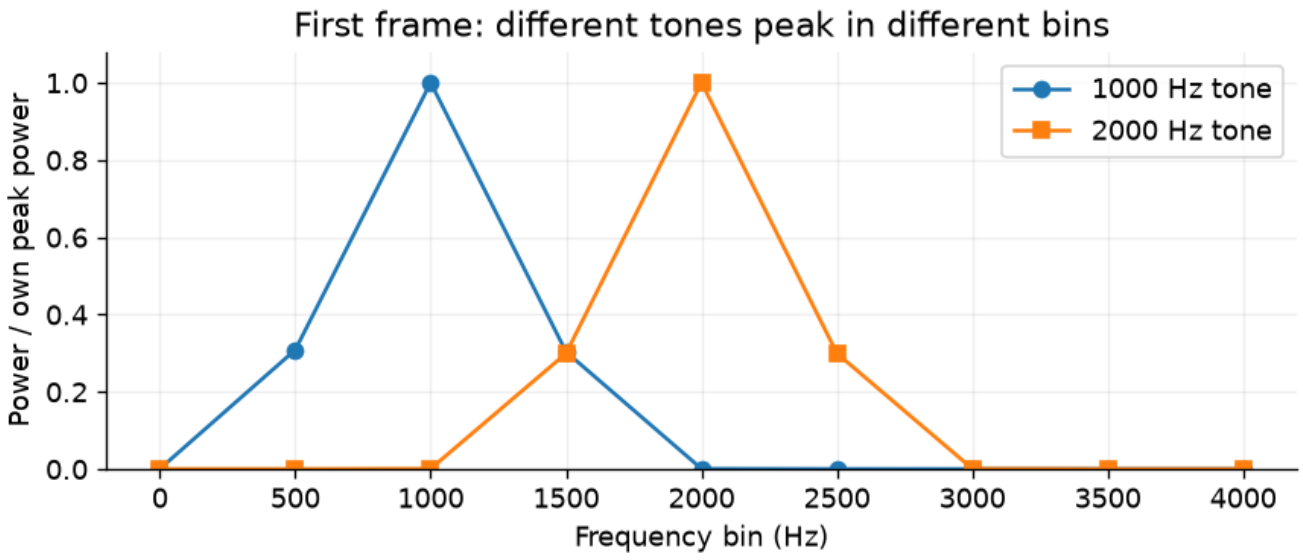
At 8,000 samples per second, a 1,000 Hz sine repeats every eight samples, so a 16-sample frame contains two cycles. A 2,000 Hz sine repeats every four samples, giving four cycles per frame. With a hop of eight, the complete frames cover indices 0–15, 8–23, and 16–31. Their starts are 0, 1, and 2 milliseconds. Each hop is a whole number of cycles for both tones, so a tone begins at the same phase in all three frames.

Bin k measures k cycles per frame. The spacing is $8{,}000/16 = 500$ Hz, so the bins run from 0 to 4,000 Hz in 500 Hz steps. We expect the 1,000 Hz tone to peak in bin 2 and the 2,000 Hz tone to peak in bin 4.

The function tapers each frame with the symmetric Hann window. For a local sample index n from 0 through 15, the weight is $w[n] = (1 - \cos(2\pi n/15))/2$. The cosine makes one full turn between indices 0 and 15, giving both end samples zero weight. A real sine has a positive and a negative frequency component. When the Fourier transform tests the matching positive bin, the phase of the positive component cancels against the phase of that bin's Fourier wave. Its contributions therefore add in proportion to the sum of the window weights. The taper also spreads energy into neighboring bins. To see which bin wins after tapering, we check all nine squared magnitudes against the direct Fourier sum with the same weights.

Using `argmax(axis=1)` picks one bin from each frame row. The peak bin is 2 in all three rows for the first tone and 4 in all three rows for the second. The first-frame comparison shows how much higher the matching bin is than the next-highest bin. The same sample pattern, with the same taper, gives the other two frames the same spectrum up to floating-point roundoff.

The peak appears at 1,000 or 2,000 Hz in every frame. Neighboring bins are nonzero because the finite Hann window spreads the spectrum. The plot normalizes each tone to its own peak to compare shape; it does not compare absolute amplitude.



7. Compare clip and corpus errors

The first reference, `go home`, has two words. The hypothesis keeps `go` and drops `home`, so one deletion gives a word error rate (WER) of $1/2$. The second hypothesis, `please turn left now`, matches its four-word reference exactly, so its WER is $0/4$.

Reference	Hypothesis	Edits	Reference words	Clip WER
go home	go	1	2	50%
please turn left now	please turn left now	0	4	0%

Pass one list of words for each reference and hypothesis. Check the returned edit counts and denominators before combining them.

Pooled WER adds the edit counts and divides by the total number of reference words. The clip mean, also called a macro average, takes the arithmetic mean of the two clip rates.

$$\mathrm{WER}_{\mathrm{pooled}} = \frac{1+0}{2+4} = \frac{1}{6}, \qquad \mathrm{WER}_{\mathrm{macro}} = \frac{1/2 + 0/4}{2} = \frac{1}{4}.$$

The clip mean gives each clip half the weight. Pooling is equivalent here to weighting the clip rates by their reference lengths. The short clip accounts for $2/6$ of the reference words and the long clip accounts for $4/6$. The error occurs in the shorter clip, so pooled WER is about 16.67% and mean clip WER is 25%.

Now add a no-speech clip that produces *thank you*. Its reference is empty, so it has two insertions and no individual WER: division by zero is undefined. Pooling it with speech adds two errors and zero reference words:

$$\mathrm{WER}_{\mathrm{pooled+silence}} = \frac{1+0+2}{2+4+0} = \frac{3}{6} = 50\%.$$

Do not replace the undefined clip rate by zero before averaging. The combined score must state which no-speech clips were included. Keep a separate false-word measure for those clips.

8. Audit a tie

The reference is `a b` and the hypothesis is `b a`. A single insertion or deletion changes the length, and a single substitution changes only one position. The words differ at both positions, so at least two edits are needed. In the table, each column of an alignment pairs a reference entry with a hypothesis entry. A dash marks a gap.

Alignment	Row	First	Second	Third
A	Reference	a	b	
A	Hypothesis	b	a	
A	Operation	Substitute	Substitute	
B	Reference	a	b	–
B	Hypothesis	–	b	a
B	Operation	Delete	Match	Insert

Alignment A substitutes both words. Alignment B deletes the first `a`, keeps the `b`, and inserts an `a` at the end. Both use exactly two edits, so both are optimal. Their counts (S, D, I) are $(2, 0, 0)$ and $(0, 1, 1)$. In either alignment the WER is $2/2 = 100\%$.

The function compares candidate final steps for each pair of prefixes. For the full pair `a b` and `b a`, all three steps have the same cost.

Final step	Prefixes before the step	Cost
Substitute final `b` with `a`	`a` and `b`	$1 + 1 = 2$
Delete final `b`	`a` and `b a`	$1 + 1 = 2$
Insert final `a`	`a b` and `b`	$1 + 1 = 2$

The code tests the diagonal first, then deletion, then insertion, and keeps the first minimum. The diagonal pairs the last reference word with the last hypothesis word and charges a substitution because they differ. Its predecessor aligns `a` with `b` by substitution, giving two substitutions in total. The implementation carries those counts forward while filling the table, so it can report them without storing the alignment.

9. Check noise without leakage

Split by speaker before making clean/noisy comparisons. For example, assign 18 speakers to training, six to validation and six to test. Keep every recording and every version of it in its speaker's split. With two recordings per speaker and two versions per recording, these groups contain 72, 24 and 24 files.

If a recording contains several speakers, group the linked speakers and recordings together before splitting. A recording-only split cannot support a new-speaker claim if the same voices appear in training and test. Similarly, a new-noise-source claim requires a noise-source split in addition to the speaker split.

Choose preprocessing, decoding and noise settings on validation; fix them before evaluating test. Record the noise source, mixing method and signal-to-noise ratio. Use identical reference normalization for clean and noisy versions. Report pooled WER separately by condition, with reference-word, clip and speaker counts. A paired illustrative result of 12 clean edits and 28 noisy edits among 200 reference words gives 6% and 14%, an eight-percentage-point gap.

For uncertainty, resample speakers and preserve each recording's clean/noisy pair. Resample connected speaker groups if recordings link speakers. The code audits grouping and checks the illustrative arithmetic; it does not estimate an ASR model's accuracy.

10. Score false words

Build separate sets of digital silence and verified non-speech background sounds, such as fans and footsteps. Listen to the clips to verify that no words are spoken. Keep duration visible because longer clips give more opportunities to invent text. Remove timestamp metadata and explicit no-speech markers before scoring transcript words; apply the same normalization and word tokenization as on speech.

Use the **false-word clip rate**: clips with at least one transcript word divided by no-speech clips. Also count false words and, when durations differ, false words per minute. In the supplied eight-clip fixture, four silent clips return no words. Among four background clips, one returns *thank you*, one returns *yes*, and two return nothing. All clips last ten seconds.

Group	Clips with words / clips	False-word clip rate	False words
Digital silence	0 / 4	0%	0
Non-speech background	2 / 4	50%	3
Combined	2 / 8	25%	3

Three words over 80 seconds give $3/(80/60) = 2.25$ false words per minute. No individual empty-reference WER is defined. If spoken clips have two errors among ten reference words, adding these three insertions gives $(2+3)/10 = 50\%$, compared with speech-only WER 20%. Report both values and the no-speech composition. A recognizer that always emits nothing can score perfectly on no-speech clips while deleting every spoken word.

These are supplied hypothetical outputs used to demonstrate scoring, not measured model responses.

11. Measure live captions

For the stated word, *turn* ends at 1.20 s. It first appears correctly at 1.35 s, giving first-correct latency $1.35 - 1.20 = 0.15$ s. The intermediate *term* at 1.48 s is a revision. Correct text remains from 1.62 s onward, so correct-stabilization latency is $1.62 - 1.20 = 0.42$ s. There are two replacements. The plot marks these events against the spoken word's end.

Stream the same recordings in real time and use checked reference word-end timestamps. Map the audio clock to a shared monotonic wall clock. Log audio capture/release, chunk delivery, every display revision, and finalization. Model emission and user-visible display are different measurement boundaries: choose one and state it. Flush the stream and observe the final output so late revisions count.

Align displayed words to reference positions with a fixed policy. Use word times when available to distinguish repetitions, and review ambiguous ties consistently. Track logical caption history so ordinary scrolling does not count as deletion. First-correct latency is the first correct appearance at that position minus the word's spoken end. Correct-stabilization latency uses the earliest correct appearance that remains correct through the final caption. Keep signed times: a correct guess can appear before the word finishes.

A never-correct word has no first-correct time. A word that becomes wrong permanently has no correct-stabilization time, even if it appeared correctly earlier. Report both coverage fractions over **all** reference words. Report median and 95th-percentile latencies where defined, revision counts, final WER, and paired differences on words with defined values for both systems. Otherwise a system could look fast by omitting difficult words.

Record hardware, runtime, precision, concurrent streams, sample rate, chunk size and cadence, lookahead, queue/buffer policy, voice-activity rules, and update/commit policy. A real-time factor of 0.2 describes total processing divided by audio duration; it does not specify these first-caption or stabilization delays.

The three-word fixture below has two words that ever appear correctly but only one that stays correct: first-correct coverage is $2/3$ and stabilization coverage is $1/3$. The second and third positions deliberately demonstrate missing values.

